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McKay Jones

Undergraduate Bioinformatics Student
Utah Valley University

Education

Utah Valley University
Bachelor of Science in Bioinformatics
Minors: Political Science, Music
Current GPA: 3.99

Orem, UT
Expected Graduation: Spring 2027

Research Experience

University of Utah School of Medicine
Undergraduate Research Assistant | Biomedical Informatics
Research Advisor: Julio Facelli, PhD, FACMI

Salt Lake City, UT
May 2025 - Present

- Investigates the etiology and onset of autoimmune diseases, using structural bioinformatics tools to understand molecular mimicry mechanisms.
- Authored two scientific papers on molecular mimicry, presented findings to academic audience of 200+ researchers.
- Awarded the Summer Program for Undergraduate Research (SPUR) internship, a nationally competitive, intensive 11-week program.

Station1
Undergraduate Research Fellow
Research Advisor: Ellan F. Spero, PhD

Cambridge, MA
September 2024-January 2026

- Researched scientific and technological innovations under Dr. Ellan Spero, Ph.D., at Station1, an MIT nonprofit advancing a new model of directional science grounded in responsibility, intentionality, and shared purpose.
- Awarded the Station1 Frontiers Fellowship, a highly competitive fully funded fellowship to participate in interdisciplinary research curriculum (100 hours), professional advancement curriculum (including machine learning and computational modeling), and over 30 assignments including a capstone research paper and presentation.

Teaching Experience

Utah Valley University Math Lab
Supplemental Instruction Leader
Orem, UT
Aug 2025 - Present

- Provides academic support to 200+ General Chemistry students every semester, by creating and distributing study guides, practice problems, and review sheets to enhance learning outcomes.
- Designs and leads 50+ group study sessions with 364+ attendees, review sessions, and workshops, modeling collaborative learning methods and techniques to empower dynamic educational teams.
- Collaborates with course instructors to align supplemental instruction sessions with course objectives and student needs.

Utah Valley University Writing Center
Graduate Writing Consultant/Fellow
Orem, UT
Aug 2024 - Present

- Actively tutors 346+ undergraduate and graduate students in 385 appointments, providing comprehensive feedback on writing through interpersonal communication.
- Partners with faculty to help writers develop knowledge, confidence, and disciplinary writing skills. Conducts class visits, workshops, and handout creation.
- Mentors students enrolled in Microbiology 4100: Parasitology and FAMS 3020: Research Methods for Family Science, empowering upcoming researchers to achieve technical purposes and communicate complex topics effectively.

Utah Valley University Writing Center
Lead Writing Fellow
Orem, UT
Jan 2026 – Present

- Designed and presented Junior-level workshops on scientific writing, APA format, and annotated bibliographies, resulting in enhanced student understanding and engagement.
- Completed CRLA 1-III and additional training on effective mentorship and designing meetings.

Utah Valley University College of Science
Teaching Assistant
Jan 2024 – May 2024

- Collaborated with Dr. Heather Wilson-Ashworth to develop innovative teaching and mentoring strategies, leading improved understanding and engagement for 50+ students.

Leadership and Community Involvement

UVU Honors Program
Honors Ambassador
Orem, UT
May 2025 – Present

- Reviewed and developed initiatives to develop the 600+ students UVU Honors Program.
- Acted as an Instructional Assistant for 100+ Colloquium students, prompting professional. development for 20+ STEM students.

Utah Department of Cultural & Community Engagement, State of Utah
College Community Engagement Councilmember
July 2024 – May 2026

- Appointed by Utah's Commission on Service and Volunteerism, CCEC members lead a year-long capstone project designed to mobilize individuals to address a community-identified need.

- Created a campus-wide resource fair featuring local nonprofits, organizations, and scientific researchers.
- Moderated a panel discussion with 5 guests, continuing conversations about air quality impacts in Salt Lake City.
- Developed learning modules to enhance digital literacy for low-income groups in Utah.

UVU Center for Social Impact
Community Building Outreach Fellow May 2024 – May 2025

- Managed and recruited 10+ team members and financed a $3000+ budget, leading applied marketing strategies that promoted campus-wide events and programs.
- Created mentorship programs that equipped 30+ students with social impact skills and resources, actively advising for 15+ hours.
- Collaborated with university faculty to present accessible research and opportunities to 450+ students and community members.

Utah International Mountain Forum
Vice President Aug 2024 – July 2025

- Served as a delegate to the 69th Commission on the Status of Women, the world's largest annual conference focused on women's issues.
- Partnered with local and international organizations to present independent research at the United Nations (UN) Headquarters in New York City.

Presentations

Oral Presentations

Map the System Global Final, University of Oxford, UK July 2025
Air Pollution in West Salt Lake Valley, Utah USA

Showcase of Scholarly & Creative Works, Utah Valley University, UT April 2025
Air Pollution in West Salt Lake Valley, Utah USA

United Nations Headquarters, New York City, NY March 2025
The Kyrgyz Republic-State of Utah Advocacy to Empower Mountain Women and Girls Through Ethically Good Student-Centric Education

Map the System Competition at Utah Valley University, UT December 2024
Air Pollution for Marginalized Groups in West Salt Lake Valley, Utah, USA
*1st Place Winners

Design for Impact Competition at Utah Valley University, UT March 2024
Alzheimer's Disease for Utah's Latinx Community
*1st Place Winners

Map the System Competition at Utah Valley University, UT December 2023
Decline in Intergenerational Social Mobility (ISM) of working-class individuals in Utah

Poster Presentations

Summer Undergraduate Research Symposium, University of Utah, UT. July 2025
Structural Homology of HHV-6 Epitopes as Candidates for Molecular Mimicry Triggers of Type One Diabetes Mellitus Onset

Intermountain Sustainability Summit, Weber State University, UT March 2025
Air Pollution in West Salt Lake Valley, Utah, USA.

Awards and Fellowships

Lt. Governor's Volunteer Recognition Certificate May 2026

Lt. Governor's Volunteer Recognition Certificate May 2025

Presidential Merit Scholarship Aug 2023 - Present

Honors Program Student Ambassador Aug 2025 - Present

UVU Social Impact Fellow Scholarship Aug 2024 – May 2025

UVUReview Senior News Editor Scholarship Aug 2024 – May 2026

Academic Merit Award Aug 2023 - Present

UVU Performing Arts: Music Scholarship Aug 2023 – May 2024

Honors Program Housing Award Aug 2023 - Present

Hope4Orem Travel Grant June 2025

Excelerate Student June 2023

Dean's List — Utah Valley University Aug 2023 – Present

Orem Kindness Hope4Orem Scholarship Aug 2023

Professional Experience

UVUReview Orem, UT
Senior News Editor/Journalist May 2024 - Present

- Wrote, edited and produced 50+ high-quality news stories for various clients, increasing the publication's search engine optimization (SEO) and social media presence.
- Conducted interviews and meetings with campus community, spreading awareness about relevant information and resources for students.
- Provided feedback and mentorship to writers, fostering growth and development in journalism.

Huntsman Cancer Institute Salt Lake City, UT
Clinical Trials Office Regulatory Intern June 2024 – Jan 2025

- Directed comprehensive training sessions for 20+ employees, enhancing their proficiency in newly implemented software systems.
- Oversaw compliance and regulatory tasks for diverse cancer studies using advanced project management tools, ensuring strict adherence to standards and deadlines.
- Collaborated with 200+ investigators and researchers to update clinical trial documentation, ensuring precision and fulfillment of the latest scientific research standards.

UVU Center for Social Impact — Orem, UT
Podcast Researcher — Aug 2023 – May 2024

- Coordinated guest speakers for 10+ episodes, establishing engaging and professional relationships.
- Promoted the Center for Social Impact to 400+ students through tabling and marketing outreach.

Certifications

College Reading and Learning Association, Master Peer Educator (Level III)	December 2025
College Reading and Learning Association, Advanced Peer Educator (Level II)	May 2025
CITI Program, Social and Behavioral Conduct of Research	May 2025
College Reading and Learning Association, Peer Educator (Level I)	December 2024
CITI Program, Biomedical Research Investigators and Key Personnel	June 2024
CITI Program ,Good Clinical Practice Course (US FDA Focus)	June 2024

Relevant Courses

Computational
- Fundamentals of Programming
- Object Oriented Programming
- Database Fundamentals
- Calculus I
- Calculus II
- Principles of Statistics
- Data Analysis for Biologists
- Introduction to Systems Administration-Linux/UNIX
- Discrete Mathematical Structures I
- Introduction to Algorithms and Data Structures
- Linear Algebra

Biology
- Principles of Chemistry I (and lab)
- Principles of Chemistry II (and lab)
- Organic Chemistry I (and lab)
- College Biology I (and lab)
- Introduction to Bioinformatics
- Molecular Biology
- Genetics
- Phylogenetics
- Molecular Evolution and Bioinformatics

Skills

Computational Skills
- SQL
- Statistics and Data Analysis in R and Python
- BASH Scripting/Linux

Other
- Microsoft Office Suite (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook)